WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

SAINT LUCIA

Americas

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Castries	Capital, seat of government and main seaport and cruise gateway, with Global Ports Holding among the investors named in the government's mega-investment pipeline	Cruise and port services, retail, financial and professional services
Rodney Bay and Gros Islet (north)	Principal resort, marina and nightlife hub, home to the planned Rodney Bay City Centre and A'ILA Resort & Spa projects and new villa openings in 2026	Hospitality, branded residences, marine services, retail
Vieux Fort and Hewanorra International Airport (south)	Main long-haul gateway, where a new three-storey terminal of about 274,300 sq ft is being procured and the new St Jude Hospital is entering service in phases	Aviation, logistics, healthcare, business process outsourcing
Soufrière and the Pitons (west coast)	Iconic heritage and luxury-tourism destination around the UNESCO-listed Pitons and focus of the country's geothermal exploration programme	Luxury and eco-tourism, geothermal energy, cruise tendering
Sabwisha, Choiseul (south-west)	Site of the planned Grand Hyatt hotel, one of the projects designated by the government as a mega-investment	Luxury hospitality, construction, local supply chains
Black Bay, Laborie (south)	Location of the Côte de Rêve development, extending tourism investment into the less developed south of the island	Resort and residential development, construction
Rural agricultural districts	Agriculture grew 7.2% in 2025, outpacing the wider economy and supporting food security and tourism supply links	Agribusiness, agro-processing, farm-to-hotel supply

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Invest Saint Lucia, the statutory investment promotion agency established under the Invest Saint Lucia Act (Cap. 15.24), which facilitates investors through approvals and incentive applications
- Fiscal Incentives Act and Tourism Incentives Act, offering income-tax waivers of up to 100% for up to 15 years, duty-free imports of inputs and hotel construction materials, and relief on property tax, stamp duty and Alien Landholding Licence fees, alongside the Special Development Areas Act
- Mega-investment framework announced by the Prime Minister in 2024, offering special incentives for large projects such as the Grand Hyatt at Sabwisha, Côte de Rêve and the Rodney Bay City Centre

- Citizenship by Investment Programme, with contributions from $240,000 to the National Economic Fund or $300,000 in approved real estate held for five years, under regional oversight from the Eastern Caribbean Citizenship by Investment Regulatory Authority (ECCIRA) from 2026
- Eastern Caribbean dollar, pegged at EC$2.70 to the US dollar for 50 years under the Eastern Caribbean Central Bank's quasi-currency board, with reserve backing of 97.6% against a 60% statutory minimum
- Public procurement and PPP opportunities in infrastructure, including the Hewanorra terminal tender run by the Saint Lucia Air and Sea Ports Authority (SLASPA), which attracted seven bids
- Income Tax Act incentives, including a 25% additional deduction on salaries for hiring university graduates for up to three years

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Saint Lucia in October 2026 is a stable, tourism-led economy regaining momentum after a soft 2025. Real GDP grew 4.7% in 2024 before contracting 0.6% in 2025 as visitor arrivals dipped, but the broader economy showed real depth: agriculture grew 7.2%, financial services 3.2% and manufacturing 2.7%. The IMF projects growth of 2.3% in 2026, and tourism is already recovering: April 2026 brought the highest April stayover total on record (40,752, up 8.5%), with arrivals up 3.7% year to date and cruise arrivals up 34% in the month. Inflation is low (projected at 1.9% for 2026), the primary balance has been in surplus for three consecutive years, and banks are well capitalised and highly liquid. The government's record EC$2.18 billion 2026/27 budget prioritises infrastructure, energy, housing and digital government, while a new airport terminal, the St Jude Hospital and a pipeline of branded resorts are broadening the investment base.

Saint Lucia's main structural challenge is the economy's concentration in tourism, which accounts for about 21% of GDP and draws 57% of visitors from the United States, leaving growth sensitive to source-market conditions and to hurricanes. The government is responding on several fronts: diversifying airlift, with WestJet and Air Canada adding capacity and Canadian and Caribbean arrivals up sharply in April 2026; building financial resilience through an approved Disaster Risk Financing Strategy, a World Bank catastrophe contingent credit line and a $20 million Disaster Risk Management financing approved in 2025; and investing more than $30 million in renewable energy to lower import costs. Public debt of about 76–77% of GDP is a constraint, but sustained primary surpluses and payables cut from over EC$160 million to about EC$20 million demonstrate fiscal discipline. For investors, the result is a well-run island with clear opportunities in resilient infrastructure, renewable energy, agribusiness and the services that broaden the tourism base.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Concentration in tourism	Tourism is about 21% of GDP, and a dip in arrivals drove the 0.6% contraction in 2025; arrivals are now recovering, with a record April in 2026	Diversifying airlift and source markets support recovery; investors can target agribusiness, health, digital and other services that complement tourism
Scrutiny of citizenship by investment	The UK introduced a visit-visa requirement for Saint Lucian nationals on 5 March 2026, citing asylum claims and CBI risks, and Caribbean CBI programmes face EU and US scrutiny	The government is engaging the UK diplomatically and regional oversight through ECCIRA is being introduced; CBI-linked projects should apply enhanced due diligence and plan for possible rule changes
Public debt	Public sector debt is about 77% of GDP (IMF, 2025), above the ECCU's 60% target for 2035, with debt service at 23% of current revenue	Three years of primary surpluses and a sharp cut in government payables show fiscal discipline; IMF-backed reforms to the medium-term fiscal framework support predictability
Hurricane and climate exposure	As a small island, Saint Lucia is exposed to hurricanes and climate change, which the IMF rates as medium-likelihood, high-impact risks	Pre-arranged disaster financing, including a World Bank contingent credit line, cushions shocks; investors should build to resilient standards and secure appropriate insurance
Labour market	Unemployment rose to 13.4% in Q2 2025, reflecting the tourism slowdown	Available labour and a 25% additional tax deduction for hiring graduates support recruitment; partnering on training adds

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
		local value
Energy costs and import dependence	Reliance on imported fuel raises electricity costs, and the Electricity Supply Bill to open the sector further is still under discussion	Renewable investment of more than $30 million, public-building retrofits and geothermal exploration create openings for solar, storage and efficiency investors
Project delivery timelines	Major projects can take time: the Hewanorra terminal is a three-to-four-year build and St Jude Hospital is being commissioned in phases	Plan for phased delivery, engage SLASPA and Invest Saint Lucia early, and partner with experienced local contractors

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Saint Lucia's risk profile is that of a politically stable, well-governed small island state with a strong currency anchor and a tourism product of international standing. The Saint Lucia Labour Party's decisive re-election in December 2025 gives policy continuity, and the 50-year EC dollar peg, backed by ECCB reserve cover of 97.6%, removes currency risk for dollar-based investors. The 2025 contraction was tourism-driven and is already reversing, with record April arrivals in 2026 and an IMF growth projection of 2.3%. Public debt of about 77% of GDP is high but is being managed through consecutive primary surpluses. The UK's March 2026 visa requirement and international scrutiny of citizenship by investment are material considerations: investors whose projects rely on CBI funding should take legal advice, apply enhanced due diligence and plan for tighter rules, while the government's diplomatic engagement and the new regional regulator point to a more robust framework. Hurricane exposure is mitigated by pre-arranged disaster financing and resilient building standards.

MARKET ACCESS

Saint Lucia is a member of CARICOM and its Single Market and Economy, the Organisation of Eastern Caribbean States (OECS) Economic Union and the Eastern Caribbean Currency Union, giving access to regional markets with a common currency and central bank. It is a WTO member and benefits from the CARIFORUM–EU and CARIFORUM–UK Economic Partnership Agreements, which provide preferential access to European and UK markets. The economy is highly open, with exports of goods and services equal to about 62% of GDP, mostly tourism receipts: the United States supplied 57% of visitors in 2024, followed by the UK, Canada and the Caribbean. Hewanorra International Airport in the south handles long-haul air links to North America and Europe, while Castries is the main seaport and cruise gateway. Rapid growth in Canadian and Caribbean arrivals in 2026 is widening the island's market base.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Philip J. Pierre)	The Prime Minister is also Minister for Finance, leading economic policy and the mega-investment agenda after the SLP's re-election in December 2025	Primary reference point for strategic direction and large-project approvals
Invest Saint Lucia	Statutory investment promotion agency handling investor facilitation and incentive applications	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive guidance
Department of Finance / Ministry of Finance	Manages the budget, public debt and fiscal incentives, and leads engagement with the IMF and development partners	Relevant for incentive approvals, PPP structures and public-investment pipeline
Eastern Caribbean Central Bank (ECCB)	Regional central bank for the eight-member currency union; maintains the EC dollar peg and supervises banks	Relevant for currency, banking and financial-sector matters
Saint Lucia Air and Sea Ports Authority (SLASPA)	Operates the island's airports and seaports and is procuring the Hewanorra terminal redevelopment	Key counterpart for aviation, port and logistics investment

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Citizenship by Investment Unit	Administers the CBI programme, a significant source of public and project financing now subject to tighter regional oversight	Essential for CBI-approved real-estate projects and for understanding rule changes
Saint Lucia Tourism Authority	Leads destination marketing and airlift development for the island's largest sector	Useful partner for hospitality investors on demand trends and route development

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Saint Lucia Chamber of Commerce, Industry and Agriculture is the main private-sector voice and runs regular briefings on the national budget and the business environment, while Invest Saint Lucia supports investor outreach and project facilitation. The Saint Lucia Development Bank channels finance to housing and enterprise, including a government-guaranteed $20 million housing credit line. Development partners are active: the World Bank provides disaster-risk financing, the IMF conducts regular Article IV reviews, the Green Climate Fund supports low-carbon investment, and the Caribbean Development Bank, the European Union and Taiwan fund infrastructure, energy and skills programmes. The ECCB's regional forums and the OECS also offer useful channels for investors with an Eastern Caribbean-wide strategy.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Saint Lucia suits investors seeking a stable, dollar-linked island economy with a premium tourism brand: hospitality and branded-residence developers targeting the island's luxury and resort segments; infrastructure and construction firms positioned for the Hewanorra terminal and other public projects; renewable-energy and efficiency investors responding to high import-based power costs; agribusiness and food-processing investors building on strong 2025 growth and hotel supply chains; and healthcare, digital and business-process investors diversifying the services base. Investors in CBI-linked real estate should weigh the evolving international regulatory environment carefully.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage Invest Saint Lucia on incentives and approvals
Open dialogue with the investment promotion agency to identify applicable incentives under the Fiscal Incentives and Tourism Incentives Acts and, for large projects, the mega-investment framework.

STEP 2: Track the Hewanorra and public-investment pipeline
Follow SLASPA's terminal procurement and the 2026/27 capital programme for construction, logistics and service opportunities in the south of the island.

STEP 3: Apply enhanced due diligence to any CBI-linked structure
Take legal advice on the UK visa decision, ECCIRA oversight and EU and US positions before relying on citizenship-by-investment funding.

STEP 4: Build resilience into project design
Use resilient construction standards, catastrophe insurance and renewable energy to protect assets and reduce operating costs.

STEP 5: Connect with the Chamber and development partners
Use the Chamber of Commerce, the Saint Lucia Development Bank and multilateral programmes to find local partners and co-financing.